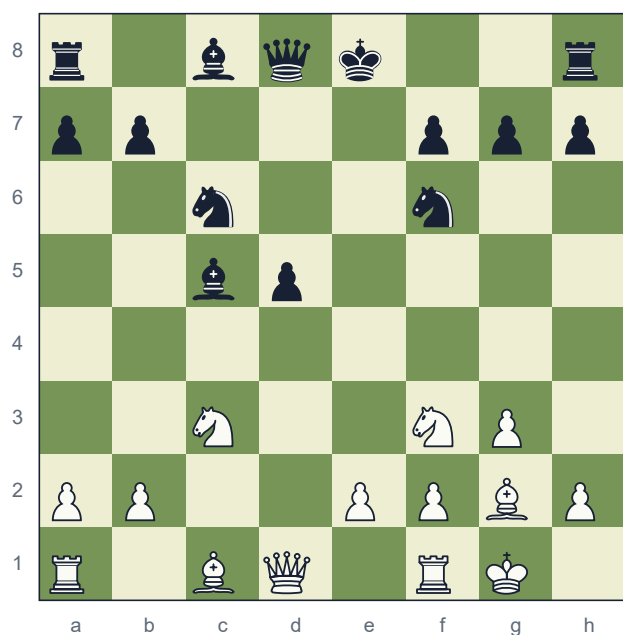


Tarrasch and Semi-Tarrasch

...e6 and ...c5 against your d4-c4 center

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Use a kingside fianchetto against the Tarrasch and a sound developing setup against the Semi-Tarrasch. Learn to handle the isolated queen pawn from both sides.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. An isolated pawn is a target only when you can blockade it.
2. The side with the isolated pawn usually wants activity and piece play, not indiscriminate simplification.
3. Trade attacking pieces before pawn-grabbing if the opponent has a lead in development.

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

In the Tarrasch, Black often has the isolated d-pawn. In the Semi-Tarrasch, exchanges can leave White with one instead. The identity of the isolated pawn matters.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

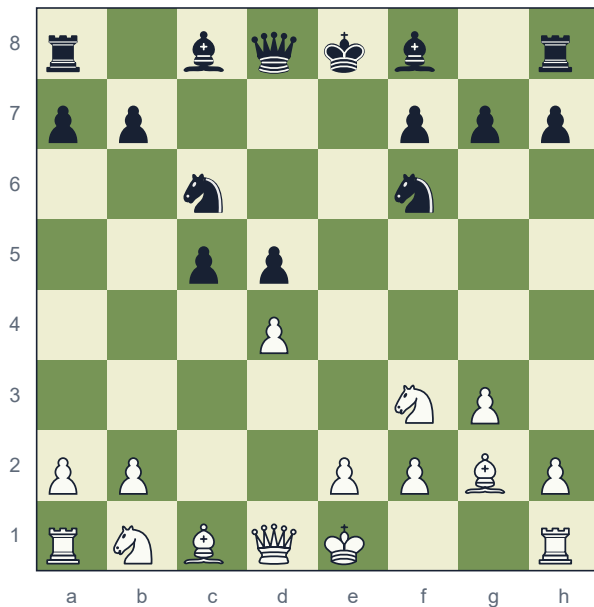
Black seeks rapid development and active central pieces. ...d4 or ...d5 can liquidate a weakness if the timing is right.

01 Tarrasch: the fianchetto setup

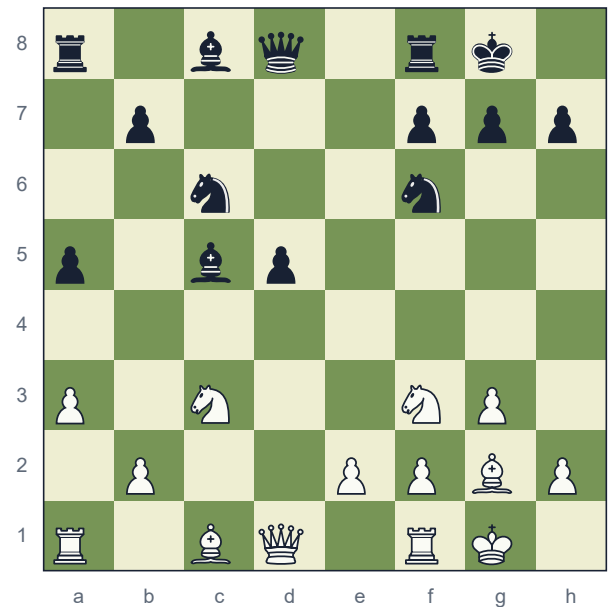
STUDY LINE 07-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. g3 Nc6 6. Bg2 Nf6 7. O-O Be7 8. dxc5 Bxc5 9. Nc3 O-O 10. a3 a5

Selected anchor ends with 9. Nc3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The bishop on g2 attacks central dark squares. Exchanging d4xc5 can leave Black with an isolated d5 pawn.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use a knight to restrain d4 and place rooks on the central files. Do not hurry to win the pawn at the expense of piece coordination.

WATCH FOR

...d4 can gain time on Nc3. Calculate the advance before parking pieces on squares it attacks.

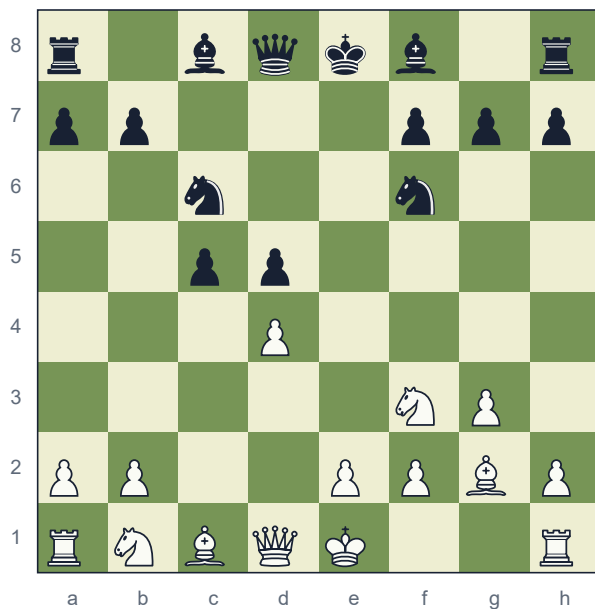
REMEMBER Blockade first; win the pawn later.

02 The ...c4 space-gaining alternative

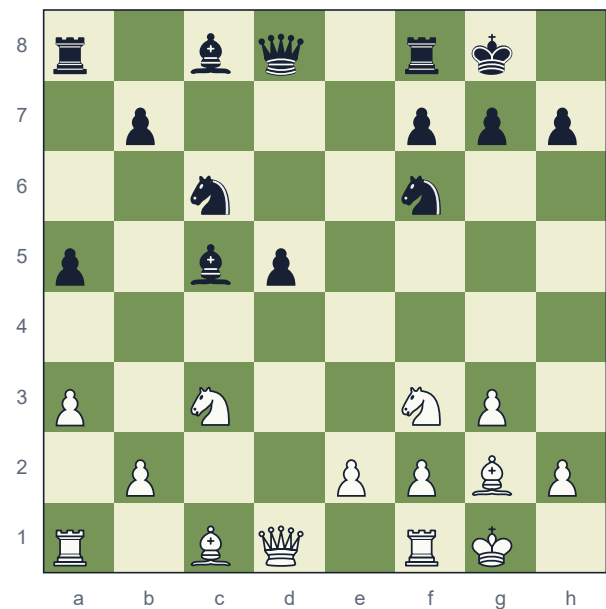
STUDY LINE 07-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. g3 Nc6 6. Bg2 Nf6 7. O-O Be7 8. Nc3 O-O 9. dxc5 Bxc5 10. a3 a5

Selected anchor ends with 8... O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White can also maintain the central tension. Black's choice between ...cxd4, ...c4 and waiting changes where your counterplay belongs.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

If ...c4 closes the queenside, a timely b3 can challenge the chain. If the center opens, the g2 bishop becomes stronger.

WATCH FOR

Do not use b3 before checking ...Bb4 and pressure on c3. A strategic break still needs tactical support.

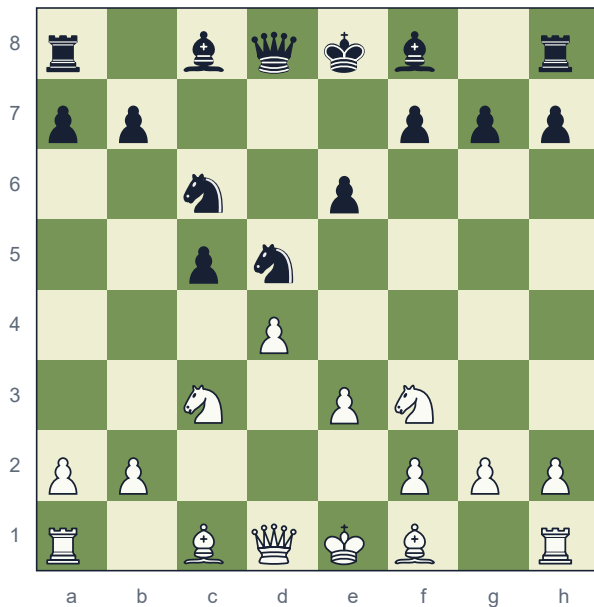
REMEMBER A locked pawn chain needs an attack on its base.

03 Semi-Tarrasch with an isolated white pawn

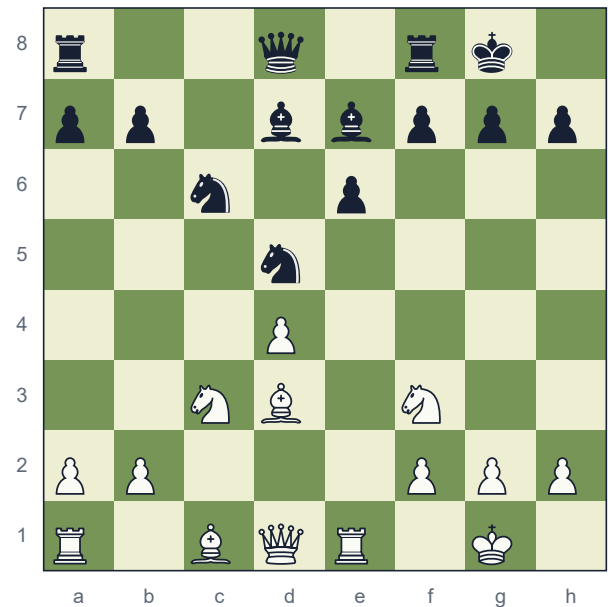
STUDY LINE 07-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e3 Nc6 7. Bd3 cxd4 8. exd4 Be7 9. O-O O-O 10. Re1 Bd7

Selected anchor ends with 10. Re1. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The e-pawn recapture keeps active central space but leaves d4 isolated. Re1 supports active piece play and a possible d5 break.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Bf4 or Bg5 when useful, bring the queen toward the center, and look for d5 when Black's pieces are uncoordinated.

WATCH FOR

Trading every minor piece can leave you defending a weak pawn in an endgame. Judge trades by activity, not by quantity.

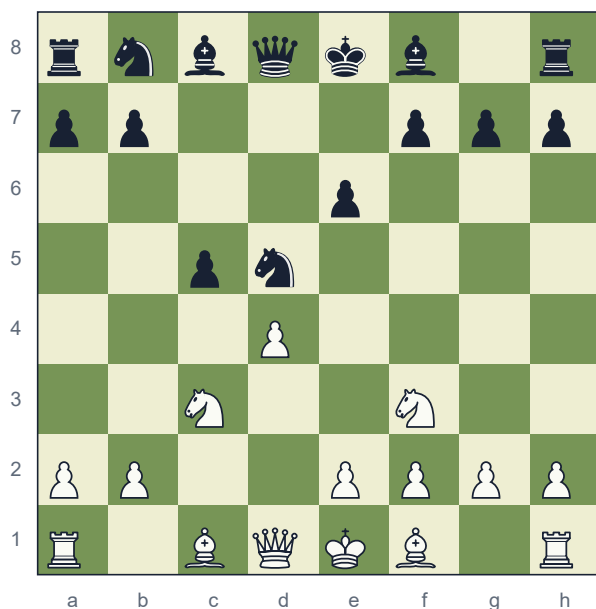
REMEMBER With the isolated pawn, play actively.

04 An early ...Nf6-c5 move order

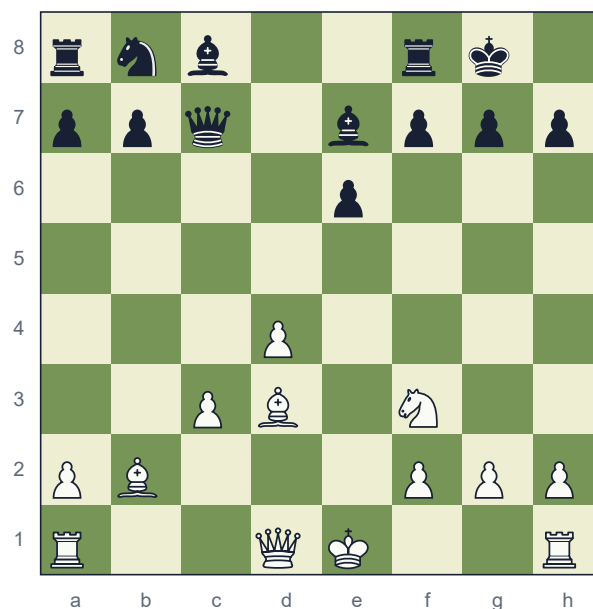
STUDY LINE 07-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e3 cxd4 7. exd4 Nxc3 8. bxc3 Qc7 9. Bb2 Be7 10. Bd3 O-O

Selected anchor ends with 6. e3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

This is the same Semi-Tarrasch through an Indian move order. The choice of 3.Nf3 did not remove ...c5 from Black's options.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

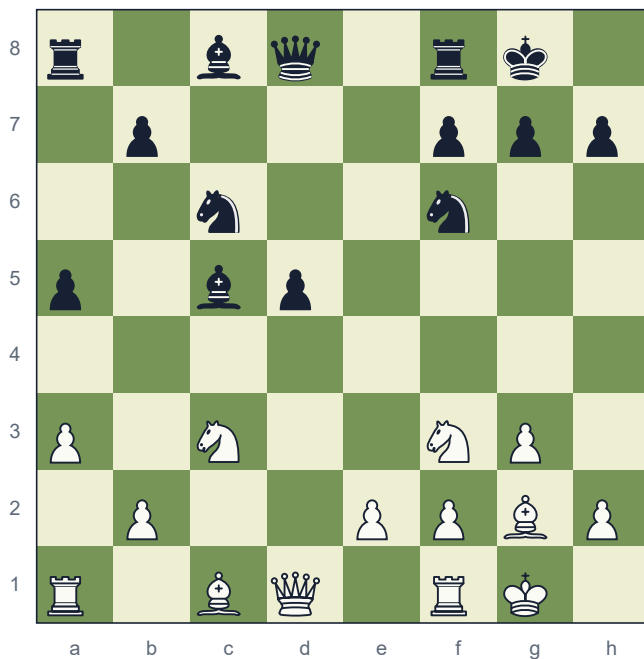
Follow the development scheme when the position matches. If Black changes the recapture, inspect the pawn structure again.

WATCH FOR

A name on a database screen is less important than the actual recapture on d5.

REMEMBER Recognize the route and verify the recapture.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

In the Tarrasch, Black often has the isolated d-pawn. In the Semi-Tarrasch, exchanges can leave White with one instead. The identity of the isolated pawn matters.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black seeks rapid development and active central pieces. ...d4 or ...d5 can liquidate a weakness if the timing is right.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Use a knight to restrain d4 and place rooks on the central files. Do not hurry to win the pawn at the expense of piece coordination.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.